



Going From Solids to Table Foods

Now that your infant has been eating spoon-fed solids for a few months they are probably starting to watch what you are eating with increased interest. In general, your child wants what you have—whether that is the cell phone you are holding, the cup you are drinking from or the food on your plate. From an evolutionary point of view, this makes sense since offspring learn what is safe to eat by watching their parents.

After getting more comfortable eating from a spoon, the natural progression is to start eating with their hands. Generally fine motor coordination in the hands corresponds with coordination in the mouth—when a child is able to pick up a small piece of food (i.e. a Cheerio) with a pincer grasp, they are usually ready to eat it. Most people start with the Gerber Puffs and/or Cheerios since they dissolve pretty quickly in the mouth. Once they get the hang of that, then you can progress to things off of your plate: rice, veggies that are a little overcooked, pasta and even meat in small pea sized pieces.

I get a lot of questions about what things are OK to feed an older infant. The easiest way to answer that question is to list what things NOT to feed a baby. Don't ever give honey to a baby under 1 year of age. (Can cause infant botulism) A recent change in recommendations from the Academy of Pediatrics is to introduce nut products, eggs, and shellfish along with other solid and table foods in the 1st year of age. For babies at increased risk of allergies, the recommendation is to actually expose the infant to peanut butter even earlier, between 4 and 6 months. Other than that, the only limit is the parents' creativity.

The contents of a burrito, bits of Chinese food and rice, little bite sized pieces of a sandwich are all perfectly good meals for an older infant/young toddler. Trying to start the meal with “something green” is always a good idea. Some fruit, left over string beans, or peas from last night's dinner can get them going before you offer a main course. Most kids, if given a choice, will chose the carb over the veggie. So offer the veggie first before you even put the pasta or grilled cheese into their view.

After nine months of age, a child can also eat a variety of dairy products. Breast milk or formula is still the staple until a year of age. However after nine months, an infant can digest whole cow's milk and all of the things made from it: cheese, yogurt, cottage cheese, even ice cream for the occasional treat. Babies who demonstrated sensitivity to cow's milk early on can usually tolerate it by a year. At nine months, a nursing mom should try reintroducing dairy into their own diet. If the baby seems fine then start by adding foods with milk “cooked in” initially and then introduce small amounts of yogurt or cheese. If there seems to be a problem, hold off. Otherwise continue to add more dairy as tolerated.

Parents often ask me if it is alright to give their baby spicy foods. Some people like bland foods, others like things a bit more spicy. Babies are people too. Some like things with a kick. (One of my sons used to love chewing on cold, sour pickles!) The only problem is that older infants and toddlers eat with their hands and then rub their face. It does not feel good to get curry sauce in your eyes! If you are mindful of that you can try most interesting foods and flavors on your child. You might be surprised by what they like.

Again as I have said in my earlier handout regarding feeding your baby:

1. You really can't do this wrong. Everybody does things differently. If you ask 10 people, you will get 10 answers.
2. Eating is one of life's great joys. It should be fun for the child and the parents. If you or your child seems stressed by food, take a step back.

Bon Appetite!